ent with him on stage were Jharkhand CM Champai Soren, and Hemant's wife Kalpana, who has emerged as a popular face in the state following her husband's arrest.

The Tribal Factor

The election year of 2024 in Jharkhand, which is also scheduled to hold an assembly election later this year, began with the arrest of Hemant Soren, son of party patriarch Shibu Soren and working president of JMM. In custody since January, the Supreme Court on May 13 sought the ED response in the case by May 17, responding to the former Jharkhand CM's plea against his arrest. Delhi CM Arvind Kejriwal, who had also been arrested in the liquor policy case, was granted "interim campaigning bail" on May 10.

With Hemant in custody, Champai Soren, a JMM leader and Shibu Soren associate, became the CM in February. Hampered by the absence of the party working president from the poll fray, Champai is putting up a brave front against his rivals. Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Champai said, "All BJP candidates seek votes in the name of Modiji. My question is straightforward: don't mention Modiji; instead, tell me what you have accomplished in the past five years as a member of Parliament."

The real JMM star this poll season, however, is 40-year-old Kalpana Soren, Hemant's wife, who is contesting the Gandey assembly by-poll scheduled for May 20 (see *Kalpana Soren Rises to the Occasion*). According to JMM sources, it has been Kalpana's emergence in the political arena that has helped lift the spirits of party workers following Hemant's arrest. At public addresses, Kalpana has pledged to "continue the struggle like my husband".

Since coming to power in the state in 2019, the JMM has endeared itself to the tribal population in Jharkhand by pushing for a domicile policy based on the 1932 Khatiyan (land record), aimed at ensuring "100 per cent job opportunities for native people—tribals and *moolvasis*". Additionally, its persistent advocacy for official recognition of the Sarna religion of the Adivasis has helped strengthen the party's support base among nature-worshipping tribals. (The BJP describes all tribals as "essentially Hindus".)

As a result, JMM leaders claim, the party's grassroots supporters are incensed by Soren's arrest. His Santhal (tribal) lineage lends weight to the Opposition's charge of the BJP-led central government purportedly being anti-tribal. "The adivasi are the *raja* [king] of *jal, jangal aur jameen* [water, forest and land]; how can you implicate a tribal leader for just a few acres of land and that too without any proof? The BJP will have to pay for it," says Vasavi Kiro, former member of the Jharkhand State Commission for Women and a

STRIKE, COU

NDA

- **Leverage the Modi wave and the PM's strong, decisive, pro-poor leader image to its advantage**
- **Use BJP state chief Babulal Marandi and President Droupadi Murmu's tribal identity to connect with the tribal voters**
- **Portray former CM Hemant Soren and state's JMM-Congress-RJD govt as corrupt**
- **Field fresh faces to buck anti-incumbency in some constituencies and micro-manage on-ground poll preparations**

KALPANA SOREN RISES TO THE OCCASION

Following her husband's arrest, she has become the public face of the party

Jail ka tala tootega," says Kalpana Soren, pausing dramatically for a loud chorus of voices to proclaim, "*Hemant Soren chhootega*". With the Enforcement Directorate's arrest of Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) working president and former Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren in an alleged land scam case in January, the political mantle in the family has passed on to his wife Kalpana. At a rally in Singhbhum on May 7, Kalpana talked of her husband's altered appearance (bearded look) when he attended his uncle's funeral rites a day before. Soren has been in custody for over three months now, and while veteran party leader Champai Soren has succeeded him as CM, it is Kalpana who has become the public face of the JMM this election season. The 40-year-old, who is contesting the Gandey

